ISSUE 03

Week of 2–8 Nov 2026

The Wild MARKETING DUMP

₹0 *not rum-flavoured*

Last week in marketing. Unfiltered.

OLD MONK GOT CARDED p.3
Not by the bouncer, by FSSAI.

SWIGGY CHANGED ITS NAME p.11
Your delivery bhaiya was literally called Sweety.

85% OF DIWALI COST UNDER ₹1,000 p.4
Kanjoos? No, smart.

IN THIS DUMP

03 **THE BIG ONE**
Old Monk can't call it rum — P.3

04 **THE DUMP**
6 stories, 6 takes — P.4–5

06 **CAMPAIGN OF THE WEEK**
Wet Ones' "hand butts" — P.6–7

08 **WILD BRAND IDEA**
BARUD, Indian chilli crisp — P.8–9

10 **NUMBER OF THE WEEK**
5.4% — P.10

11 **INDIAN BRAND WATCH**
Sweety, Saif and a cartoon war — P.11

12 **STEAL THIS × WILD GYAAN**
Variable rewards — P.12

13 **AI & MARKETING**
AI cats, Reddit search ads — P.13

14 **WHERE DID THE MONEY GO?**
$255M, and who got it — P.14

15 **PEOPLE MOVES**
Who went where — P.15

THE BIG ONE

OLD MONK CAN'T CALL IT RUM

FSSAI says some of it is "rum-flavoured spirit". McDowell's and Antiquity Blue got flagged too.



<5%

Matured rum in the Old Monk XXX labelled "7 Years Old Blended". The rest: unaged neutral spirit.

₹350 cr

Excise revenue the maker says Maharashtra lost to the sales ban.

FSSAI's August order stopped sale of select variants of Old Monk, McDowell's No. 1, Antiquity Blue, Royal Challenge and Bagpiper: flavouring that mimics rum in rum. On 5 Nov, Old Monk's maker dropped its Bombay HC plea and will relabel.

MY TAKE

Sixty-plus saal ki legacy, and the problem was one word on the label. Your brand story is only as strong as the claim you can prove, yaar.

ADGULLY, 5 NOV · ESQUIRE INDIA, 4 AUG · DECCAN HERALD

THE DUMP

What happened, and what I think.

1 DIWALI SHOPPING WAS SMALL AND FAST

85% of festive orders were under ₹1,000. Quick commerce volumes grew 75%, D2C sites grew 30%, and Tier-3 cities placed 41% of orders.

> *India isn't buying less, it's buying smaller. If your cheapest SKU costs ₹1,500, you missed Diwali.*

2 BRANDS ARE BUILDING CAMPAIGNS AROUND RAMAYANA

Tribe Amrapali, Mangalmai, ITC Mangaldeep and UFO Moviez go beyond product placement. Dabur is holding back.

> *The test: are you adding to the conversation or just borrowing the film's fame? Most brands, sorry, are borrowing.*

3 "EVERY DIWALI REEL LOOKS THE SAME BECAUSE THE BRIEF DOES"

Zoo Media's Pratik Gupta: 20–30% mega creators, the rest mid to nano, and sales metrics agreed before the creative.

> *"Content that ends in a basket beats content that ends in a like." Bas, frame it.*

MEDIANEWS4U, 6 NOV · AFAQS!, 5 NOV

THE DUMP, CONT'D

Brands playing a different game.

4 L'ORÉAL MADE A MICRODRAMA TO SELL "GHOSTING SPRAY"

Urban Decay's six-episode "Ghost Hunter Hotline" was made in about four weeks and got 3.8M views in five days.

> *A product called Ghosting Spray in a show about ghosting. Itna on-brand hona chahiye.*

5 PINTEREST GREW BY DOING THE OPPOSITE OF SOCIAL MEDIA

CMO Claudine Cheever on reaching 640M monthly users by building around intent, not endless scrolling.

> *Everyone's fighting for your attention. Pinterest asked what you want to do next. Counter-positioning ka textbook case.*

6 AN INDIAN ARTIST PUT DIWALI ON A BAYERN JERSEY

Abhay Sehgal's hand-painted kit has elephants, a diya and a "00" for Aryabhata's zero. Kane, Neuer and Gnabry wore it.

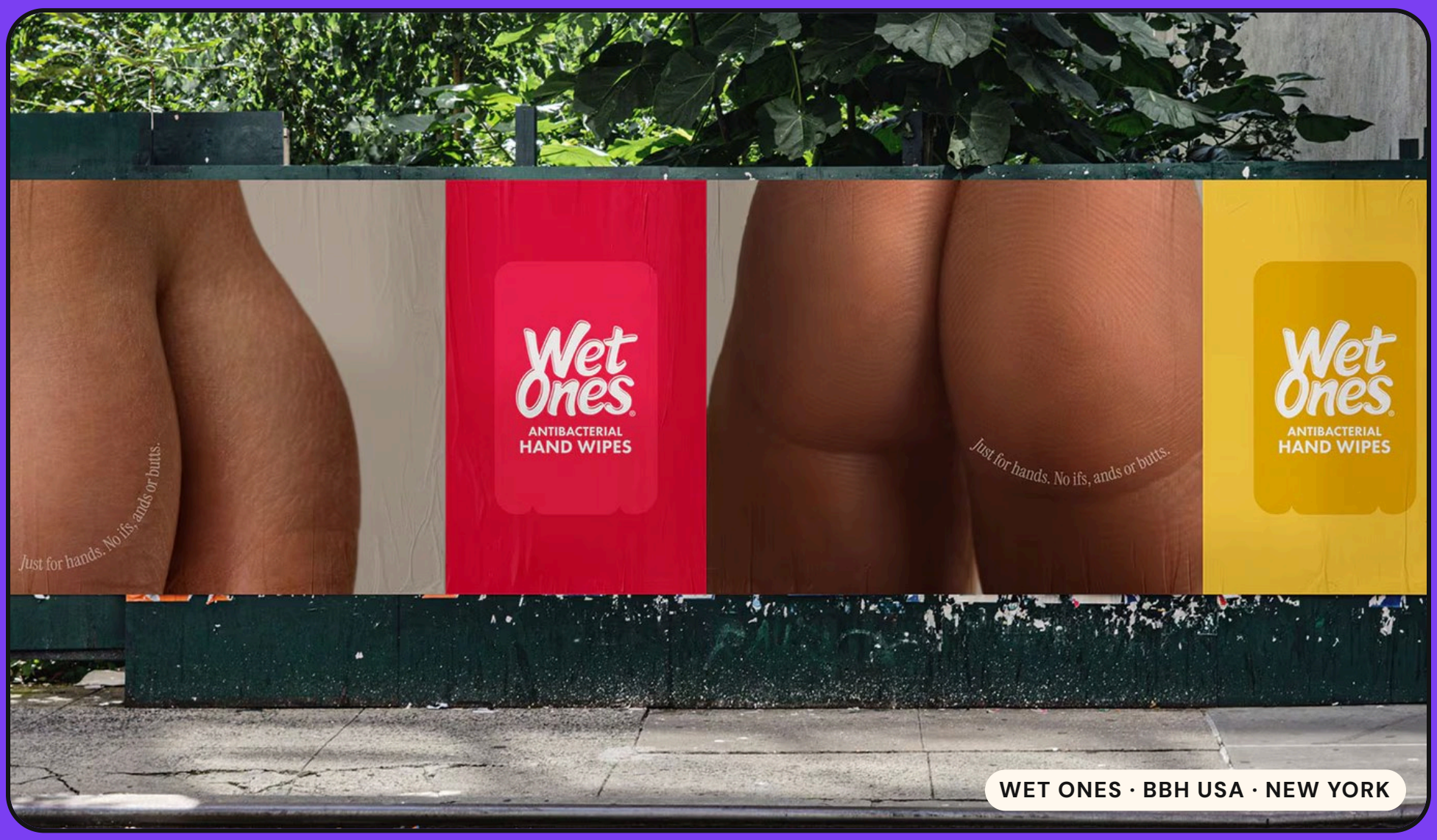
> *No Bollywood face, just Indian craft. And that "00" detail? Screenshot-worthy.*

MARKETING DIVE, 5 NOV · UNCENSORED CMO, 4 NOV · ADGULLY, 6 NOV

CAMPAIGN OF THE WEEK

JUST FOR HANDS

Wet Ones put "hand butts" all over New York.



WET ONES · BBH USA · NEW YORK

WHAT THEY DID

Extreme close-ups of fingers posed to look like bottoms, on LinkNYC kiosks, bus wraps, a Times Square takeover and walls that handed out wipes.

MARKETING DIVE, 6 NOV

CAMPAIGN OF THE WEEK

07/16

BANNED.

The MTA said it was too risqué for the subway. Wet Ones turned that into free PR.

THE INSIGHT

Edgewell's research: more than half of people have used hand wipes on an intimate area.

THE MOVE

Say the embarrassing truth out loud, and be ready when someone objects.

HOW IT WORKS

1

FIND THE AWKWARD TRUTH

How people really use wipes.

2

MAKE IT CHEEKY

Fingers posed like bums, all over NYC.

3

RIDE THE REACTION

Goodwipes poked fun; the reply was up in Times Square within hours.

WHY I PICKED IT

Most brands hide the awkward truth. Wet Ones made it the brief. And when they got banned, they were ready. Shameless, in the best way.

MARKETING DIVE, 6 NOV

WILD BRAND IDEA

INDIA GAVE THE WORLD ITS SPICES, AND THEN WE IMPORTED OUR CHILLI OIL.

Nobody put Indian fire in a bottle.

CATEGORY

Chilli crisp. Every fridge now has that one chilli crisp jar. Eggs, Maggi, momos, everything gets a drizzle.

WHITE SPACE

India already had its own fire: gunpowder podi in Andhra, thecha in Kolhapur, bhut jolokia in the Northeast. **Problem? They're powders and pastes, not something you can drizzle.**



@NEHARUNSWILD

WILD MARKETING DUMP

WILD BRAND IDEA

MEET BARUD.

Indian chilli crisp.

THE RANGE

GUNTUR GUNPOWDER
Fine podi in oil, for your dosa and eggs.

KOLHAPURI THECHA
Green chilli and garlic, for Maggi and toast.

NAGA FIRE
Bhut jolokia, for the momos. Proceed with caution.

THE LAUNCH

We send our interns to the best momo spots in town with just one bottle: **NAGA FIRE.** They hand it to people eating momos, hit record and watch the faces.



POSITIONING

INDIAN FIRE, IN A BOTTLE.

NUMBER OF THE WEEK

5.4%

YOUNG INDIANS IN TIER 2-4 CITIES WHO FIRST HEAR ABOUT PRODUCTS THROUGH TV OR PRINT ADS.

55.8% first hear about products on Instagram

73.1% trust family and friends most

MY TAKE

They find you on Instagram, but they buy because mummy said yes. Discovery is digital, trust is still the family WhatsApp group.

MSL INDIA × YOUTH KI AWAAZ SURVEY OF 3,509 UNDER-30S, VIA AFAQS!, 4 NOV

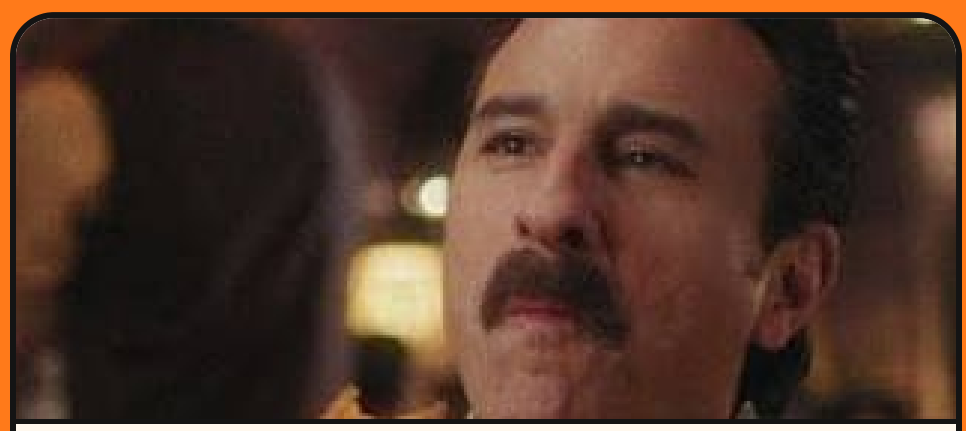
INDIAN BRAND WATCH

Five moves worth stealing.



SWIGGY → SWEETY

New name on hoardings, rider T-shirts and in the app. Kareena brought back Poo for it.



ZOMATO × SAIF

"Not everyone needs another bedsheet this Diwali."



BGMI

Roasts its rival as the "Cartoon Waala Game", without naming it.



TEMPLE

₹85,000 headband. No ads, just Shubman and Sindhu wearing it. Site crashed.



HYUNDAI × TTT

A Diwali micro-drama where a vintage Santro is the family memory.

THE PATTERN

Funny how husband and wife became the faces of rivals Swiggy and Zomato this Diwali. Zomato went the ad route, Swiggy went the other way.

MEDIANEWS4U 6–7 NOV · AFAQS! 6–8 NOV · ADGULLY 7 NOV · SWIGGY ON INSTAGRAM · BRAND IMAGES

MAKE THE DEAL MOVE.

AJIO's mystery astronaut unlocks better deals the closer he gets to your city.



AJIO · "GHAR WAPSI" BY 22FEET

WILD GYAAN · VARIABLE REWARDS

We come back more often to things that *might* reward us than to things that always do. Nir Eyal calls it the variable reward in his Hook Model. Read: *Hooked*, Nir Eyal.

1

MAKE IT MOVE

Give people a target to track.

2

MAKE IT GET BETTER

The closer he gets, the better the deal.

3

MAKE THEM CHECK

A reason to open the app again.

AI & MARKETING

What the machines did to marketing this week.

1 FRESH STEP MADE TV ADS WITH AI TALKING CATS

Clorox's cat litter brand went from brief to three 15-second spots in 30 days, at about a tenth of the usual cost. AI was used to test concepts before production.

> *Cheap is the headline, but the real story is testing the idea before making it. Strategists, ab bahaana khatam.*

2 REDDIT IS TESTING SEARCH ADS

AI chatbot traffic "has started to dry up": search referrals fell by more than 1 million a week in October. 72% of users come looking for information.

> *Everyone wants to keep your search inside their own app now. Where people talk about you matters as much as where you advertise.*

WHERE DID THE MONEY GO?

$255M

raised by Indian startups across 20 deals, 2–6 Nov. GIVA took most of it.

BRAND	WHAT IT SELLS	RAISED	LED BY
GIVA	Silver, gold and lab-grown diamond jewellery	₹975 cr	Multiples
ELOELO	Consumer AI and entertainment	$80M	NBCUniversal, Hornbill Capital
CROFFLE GUYS	QSR (croffles)	$1.4M	V3 Ventures
SOLGRAM	Quick commerce consumer services	$1M	DSG Consumer Partners, Saama
HYEGLO	D2C beauty	$744K	Sauce

MY TAKE

The biggest D2C cheque of the week went to a brand that wants to stop being D2C. GIVA wants 75–80% of sales from stores. Online gets you famous, offline gets you profitable.

INC42, 3 & 7 NOV

PEOPLE MOVES

Who went where this week.

MCDONALD'S USA

ALYSSA BUETIKOFER LEAVES AS CMO

Out on 18 Dec after 15 years. Morgan Flatley is interim chief creative officer, Charlie Newberger interim US chief marketing and commercial officer.

TITAN

NOEL TATA RETIRES AS VICE-CHAIRMAN

On 12 Nov, his 70th birthday, under Tata Group age rules. He stays Chairman of Tata Trusts.

OLD NAVY

MICHAEL FRANCIS → CEO

Started on 2 Nov. The "Jingle Jet" holiday campaign with Alan Cumming and Paris Hilton is his first.

MARKETING DIVE, 5 NOV · ADGULLY, 6 NOV

THAT'S THE DUMP.

See you next Monday.

MARKETING WEATHER

↑	↓	!!
RISING	**COOLING**	**STORMY**
Brands that roast	Bedsheet hampers	Label claims

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